

Diego Romero

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University of Texas at Austin
Lyndon B. Johnson School of Public Affairs
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Employment

- 2025 - . LBJ School of Public Affairs, *The University of Texas at Austin*.
Assistant Professor.
- 2023 - 2025. Department of Political Science, *Utah State University*.
Assistant Professor.
- 2022 - 2023. PDRI-Devlab@Penn, Department of Political Science, *University of Pennsylvania*.
Postdoctoral Research Associate.
- 2019 - 2022. Machine Learning for Peace Project, Devlab@Duke, *Duke University*.
Doctoral Researcher.

Affiliations

- 2025 - Present. Faculty Affiliate, Center for Law and Democracy, *University of Texas at Austin*
- 2025 - 2026. Fellow, GLD Institute, *University of Gothenburg*
- 2023 - Present. Research Affiliate, PDRI-Devlab@Penn, *University of Pennsylvania*

Education

Duke University

- 2022, May. Ph.D. Political Science.
Dissertation: “Connections and Privileged Access: Essays on The Political Economy of Corruption”
— Awarded Outstanding Dissertation, Duke University Department of Political Science, 2022

Duke University

- 2016 M.A. Economics.

Chapman University

- 2013 B.A. Economics, *magna cum laude*.

Publications

Articles

1. Diego Romero. “Unpacking Bribery: Petty Corruption and Favor Exchanges.” *Latin American Politics and Society*, 67(2):36-59, 2025. Doi: <https://doi.org/10.1017/lap.2024.50>

2. Diego Romero. "Bureaucratic Capacity and Political Favoritism in Public Procurement." *Comparative Political Studies*, 58(6): 1067-1100, 2024. Doi: <https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140241259448>
3. Elaine K. Denny, Ngoc Phan, Diego Romero, and Erik Wibbels. "Incentives, Audits and Corruption: Evidence from a District-Level Field Experiment in Ghana." *Governance*, 37(3): 729-750, 2024. Doi: <https://doi.org/10.1111/gove.12798>
4. David Dow, Gabriella Levy, Diego Romero, and Juan F. Tellez. "State Absence, Vengeance, and the Logic of Vigilantism in Guatemala." *Comparative Political Studies*, 57(1): 147-181, 2024. Doi: <https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140231169026>
5. Gary Bland, Derick Brinkerhoff, Diego Romero, Anna Wetterberg, and Erik Wibbels. "Public Services and the Geography of Citizen Perceptions of Government in Latin America and the Caribbean." *Political Behavior*, 45: 125-152, 2023. Doi: <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11109-021-09691-0>
6. Elaine K. Denny, David Dow, Diego Romero, and Erik Wibbels. "Remittances, Unemployment, and Deportees' Decision to Remigrate in a COVID-19 Era." *Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy*, 2(1): 1-21, 2021. Doi: <http://dx.doi.org/10.1561/113.00000027>

Book Chapters

1. Timur Kuran and Diego Romero. "The Logic of Revolutions: Rational Choice Perspectives." In Roger D. Congleton, Bernard Grofman, and Stefan Voigt (Eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Public Choice* (Volume 2, pp. 345-360). Oxford University Press, 2019.

Under Review

1. Serkant Adiguzel, Zung-Ru Lin, Donald Moratz, Diego Romero, Mahda Soltani, Jeremy Springman, Hanling Su, Jitender Swami, Mateo Villamizar-Chaparro, and Erik Wibbels. "Tracking Civic Space in Developing Countries with a High-Quality Corpus of Domestic Media and Transformer Models."
2. Diego Romero, Agnes Cornell, and Marcia Grimes. "Do the Mobilized Mobilize? Experimental Evidence from Civil Society Leaders in Guatemala."
3. Diego Romero, Mateo Villamizar-Chaparro, and Erik Wibbels. "The Market in Smugglers: Survey Experimental Evidence on the Choice of *Coyotes* in Guatemala."
4. Jeremy Springman, Serkant Adiguzel, Zung-Ru Lin, Donald Moratz, Diego Romero, Mateo Villamizar-Chaparro, and Erik Wibbels. "Foreign Influence by Authoritarian Governments: Introducing New Data and Evidence."

Selected Working Papers

1. Diego Romero. "Exposure to Corruption and Perceptions of State Capacity."
2. Serkant Adiguzel, Diego Romero, and Erik Wibbels. "Autocratization and Media Responses to Government Repression: Machine Learning Evidence from Tanzania."
3. Serkant Adiguzel, Diego Romero, and Marco Morucci. "Paying the dues? Access, Congestion and Bribery."

4. Elaine K. Denny, David Dow, Diego Romero, Juan F. Tellez, Mateo Villamizar-Chaparro, Erik Wibbels, and Pamela Zabala. “The Human Impact of Deportation: Resettlement and Remigration.”
5. Maria Nagawa and Diego Romero. “Perceptions of Meritocratic Recruitment and Willingness to Pay Taxes”
6. David Dow, Diego Romero, and Livia Schubiger. “Trust and Public Institutions: Reporting of Gender-based Violence in Guatemala.”
7. Shanze Fatima Rauf, Diego Romero, and Erik Wibbels. “The Revolution Starts at Home: Within Household Female Support and Women’s Civic Engagement.”
8. Serkant Adiguzel, Diego Romero, and Erik Wibbels. “The Impact of Legal Repression on Citizen Online Behavior: Evidence from Tanzania’s Jamii Forums.”
9. Diego Romero. “Stopping Democratic Backsliding: The 2023 Guatemalan Elections and *Movimiento Semilla*’s Rise.”
10. Diego Romero and Joséphine Lechartre. “The Economic Foundations of Illicit Power: DTO Strategies and Their Political Consequences in Guatemala”

Reports and Public Writing

1. “Press Freedom and Reporting on Corruption: Evidence from the Machine Learning for Peace Project.” With Jitender Swami and Erik Wibbels.
2. “Information, Civil Society and Corruption: Evidence from a Randomized Control Trial in Guatemala.” With Erik Wibbels.
3. “High-Frequency Evidence on Corruption in 53 Countries: New Data from the MLP Project.” With Jitender Swami and Erik Wibbels.
4. “The Impact of Legal Repression on Citizen Online Behavior: Evidence from Tanzania’s Jamii Forums.” With Serkant Adiguzel, Nuzulack Dausen, and Erik Wibbels.
5. “The Impact of Legal Restrictions on Media in Tanzania.” With Serkant Adiguzel, and Erik Wibbels. Prepared for the *United States Agency for International Development, Center for Democracy, Human Rights and Governance Center*.
6. “El impacto humano de la deportación: análisis de los desafíos de la reinserción de los migrantes retornados.” *Actualidad Política*. With Elaine K. Denny, David Dow, Wayne Pitts, Juan Tellez, Mateo Villamizar-Chaparro, Erik Wibbels, and Pamela Zabala.
7. “Deportados: En Guatemala solo hay carencias, por eso quieren volver.” *Plaza Pública*. With Elaine K. Denny, David Dow, Wayne Pitts, Juan Tellez, Mateo Villamizar-Chaparro, Erik Wibbels, and Pamela Zabala.
8. “Reporting on Civic Space: Differences in Coverage Between National and International Sources.” Prepared for the *Machine Learning for Peace Project* with Serkant Adiguzel, Mike Sun, and Erik Wibbels.
9. “Encuesta a deportados: solo quieren volver a huir del país.” *Plaza Pública*. With Elaine K. Denny, David Dow, Wayne Pitts, Juan Tellez, Mateo Villamizar-Chaparro, Erik Wibbels, and Pamela Zabala.

10. “Julio, dos veces castigado: deportado y tratado como criminal en su país.” *Plaza Pública*. With Erik Wibbels and José Andrés Ordoñez.
11. “4 things the Biden administration should pay attention to with the border crisis.” *The Brookings Institution*. With Elaine K. Denny, David Dow, José Andrés Ordoñez, Wayne Pitts, Juan Tellez, Mateo Villamizar-Chaparro, Erik Wibbels, and Pamela Zabala.

Grants, Honors, and Awards

- 2026. Seed Grant, Teresa Lozano Long Institute of Latin American Studies (w. Isabel Laterzo-Tingley, Ayelén Vanegas, and Karin Vervuurt) (\$10,000)
- 2024-2025. USAID/Guatemala and OCE: Impact Evaluation Scoping for a Citizen Security Activity Project (Principal Investigator). (\$59,666)
- 2024-2025. USAID Democracy, Human Rights, and Governance Bureau: “Mixed-Methods Approach to Distinguishing Genuine from Self-Serving Anticorruption Campaigns” (with CEPPS/IFES, D-ARCH Internews, and PDRI-DevLab@Penn) (\$46,690)
- 2024-2025. USAID Democracy, Human Rights, and Governance Bureau: “El Salvador Strategic Communications” (with Social Impact). (Pro-bono consulting)
- 2022-2023. INSPIRES Flexible Response Funds: “Information, Civil Society and Corruption in Guatemala” (\$68,613).
- 2022-2023. INSPIRES Flexible Response Funds: “Fake Media, Corruption and Democratic Backsliding in El Salvador” (with Erik Wibbels, \$50,804).
- 2022. Outstanding Dissertation Award, Duke University Department of Political Science.
- 2022. 2020-2021 Quality of Government Institute Best Paper Award, University of Gothenburg. (€400).
- 2022. CLACS Conference Travel Grant (\$350).
- 2020. CLACS 2020 Graduate Student Field Research Grant, Duke University (\$2,500).
- 2020. Molano Endowment Research Award Grant, Duke University (\$5,000).
- 2019. Molano Endowment Research Award Grant, Duke University (\$1,500).
- 2019. Outstanding Preliminary Paper Award, Duke University.
- 2018. CLACS 2018 Graduate Student Field Research Grant, Duke University (\$2,500).
- 2018. DUCIGS Graduate Research & Training Competition Grant, Duke University (\$2,500).
- 2017. Molano Endowment Research Award Grant, Duke University (\$4,500).
- 2014. Programa Crédito-Beca, Guatefuturo (\$45,000).
- 2013. Argyros Scholar, Argyros School of Business and Economics, Chapman University.
- 2013. University Honors Award for Academic Excellence, Chapman University.
- 2013. University Honors Student of the Year Award, Chapman University.
- 2012. Faculty Academic Recognition, Argyros School of Business and Economics, Chapman University.

Presentations

- 2026 (Mar). “Building Democratic Resilience: Institutions and Attitudes in Latin America” Conference. Organizer and presenter.
- 2025 (Oct). Northeast Political Economy Conference (NPEC). Presenter.

2025 (Apr). “Information, Civil Society, and Corruption: Evidence from Guatemala.” Farewell Lecture, Latin American Studies Program, Utah State University.

2024 (Jun). Latin American Studies Association (LASA) 2024. Presenter.

2024 (Apr). Political Economy of Development Conference, PDRI-DevLab@Penn, University of Pennsylvania. Presenter.

2024 (Apr). Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting. Presenter, discussant, and session chair.

2023 (Oct). 6th Academia against Corruption in the Americas (ACA) Conference. Presenter.

2023 (Aug). American Political Science Association Annual Meeting. Presenter.

2023 (Apr). “Migration, Deportation and the Consequences for Central America.” Center for the Americas (University of Oklahoma), and Center for Inter-American Policy and Research (Tulane University). Panelist.

2022 (Oct). Big Data for Development and Governance Conference, DevLab@Penn, University of Pennsylvania. Organizer and presenter.

2022 (Oct). QoG Seminar, Quality of Government Institute, University of Gothenburg. Presenter.

2022 (Jun). Copenhagen Business School’s Money in Politics Conference. Presenter.

2022 (Apr). Duke/UNC Latin American Politics Working Group’s Mini-Conference. Presenter.

2022 (Apr). Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting. Presenter.

2022 (Mar). NCCLAS/SECOLAS Conference in Charlotte, NC. Discussant.

2021 (Oct). American Political Science Association Annual Meeting. Presenter.

2021 (May). Frontiers in Political Science: Latin American Politics and Party Competition. Presenter, discussant.

2021 (Apr). Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting. Presenter.

Workshops

2025 (Jun). Public Sector Organizational Effectiveness, University of Notre Dame.

2024 (Jan). 1st. Central American Politics Consortium Workshop, Tulane University.

2022 (May). Southern Workshop in Empirical Political Science (SoWEPS-5), Rice University.

Policy Talks

2024 (May). Co-presenter at CEPPS Learning Forum, “Digital Detection: Using Technology to Understand and Respond to Corruption.”

2023 (Oct). Presenter at “Machine Learning for Peace: Herramientas Digitales para la Acción Cívica,” Partners Global Honduras and USAID.

2023 (Sep). Panelist at ASIES and DevLab@Penn’s “Análisis de contrataciones públicas municipales y el efecto de la información.”

2023 (Aug). Presenter at “Changes in Citizen-Driven Online Content in Tanzania,” INSPIRES Consortium, USAID.

2023 (Aug). Presenter at the R+ Cohort 3 Final Learning and Networking Event (LAC), INSPIRES Consortium, USAID.

2022 (Aug). Panelist at ASIES’s “Una mirada a la migración en Centroamérica.”

2022 (May). Interview at Canal Antigua’s *A las 8:45* about the impact of mass deportations to Guatemala.

2022 (May). Panelist at ASIES and DevLab@Duke’s “Migración y retorno en Guatemala y el norte de Centroamérica.”

2022 (Jan). Presentation to *INSPIRES*’ partners in Guatemala: “Una nueva herramienta para los defensores de la democracia: Pronósticos sobre el Espacio Cívico con Machine Learning for Peace.”

2021 (Nov). Panelist at Sandford School of Public Policy LAC Student Group’s “Policy Responses to Migration” Panel (with Erik Wibbels).

2021 (Oct). Presentation to *Internews*: “National Versus International Media Coverage of Civic Space” (with Erik Wibbels).

Teaching Experience

2026. *Policymaking in a Global Age*, University of Texas at Austin, Lyndon B. Johnson School of Public Affairs.

2025. *Anti-Corruption Policy and Practices Around the World*, University of Texas at Austin, Lyndon B. Johnson School of Public Affairs.

2024. *Research Design*, Utah State University, Department of Political Science.

2023-2025. *Introduction to Political Research*, Utah State University, Department of Political Science.

2024-2025. *Latin American Government and Politics*, Utah State University, Department of Political Science.

2023. *Global Development: Intermediate Topics in Politics, Policy and Data*, University of Pennsylvania, Department of Political Science.

2022. *Natural Language Processing for Journalists*, workshop for journalists from *Gato Encerrado* (El Salvador).

2018. *Political Economy of Latin America*, Teaching Assistant for Karen Remmer.

2018. *Introduction to Political Science*, Teaching Assistant for Michael Munger.

Service

Reviewer: *Journal of Comparative Economics*, *British Journal of Political Science*, *Comparative Political Studies*, *Latin American Politics and Society*, *International Journal of Comparative and Applied Criminal Justice*.

University service: Online teaching committee, Department of Political Science, Utah State University, 2024.

Other service: Member of the planning committee for *Academia Against Corruption in the Americas*; co-organizer of the Duke/UNC Latin American Working Group (2017-2019)

Research Skills

Programming Languages: R, Python, JavaScript

Statistical software: Stata

Data Collection Platforms: Open Data Kit (ODK), SurveyCTO

GIS Software: ArcGIS

Database Management: MongoDB

Languages: Spanish (Native speaker), English (Fluent), Turkish (Intermediate)